DID YOU KNOW?

A shared thread between two of Doordarshan's most-watched shows in the 1980s was the legendary Ashok Kumar. In *Hum Log*, he summarised each episode with a moral lesson, while in *Ramayana*, he lent his voice as the narrator.

Thanks to TV, Bollywood got one of its biggest superstars: Shah Rukh Khan. He first acted in *Fauji* and *Circus* before moving to Mumbai to make his big-screen debut in *Deewana*.

TV'S BIG LEAP

» **1984** Inspired by a Mexican soap opera, ***Hum Log*** is the first sponsored show on Doordarshan. ***Yeh Jo Hai Zindagi*** becomes one of the first sitcoms to air on Doordarshan

» Filmmakers Kundan Shah, Saeed Mirza, Shyam Benegal, Gulzar, Pankaj Parashar create programmes for DD

» **1987** TV viewership peaks as ***Ramayan*** becomes a Sunday morning viewing ritual for families, followed by B.R.Chopra's ***Mahabharat***. The Reliance World Cup is one of the high points of live telecast

India Today Group's video magazine ***Newstrack*** offers an alternative to DD and AIR

» **1992** Zee TV becomes the first private channel to launch in India. After re-running DD shows, it starts original programming with ***Tara*** and ***Antakshari***

» **1995** Privatisation of news begins with the launch of Zee News, NDTV starting News Tonight and TV Today Network procuring a 20-minute slot on DD Metro for its Hindi news show, ***Aaj Tak***. Five years later, it is a 24-hour news channel

» **2000** Ekta Kapoor's Balaji Telefilms kicks off the ***saas-bahu*** drama tsunami with ***Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*** and ***Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki*** on Star

» Amitabh Bachchan resurrects his career as he starts hosting ***Kaun Banega Crorepati*** on Star

» Amid the deluge of family melodramas, B.P. Singh launches ***CID***, which becomes one of the longest-running shows

» ***Bigg Boss*** gives reality show format a salacious twist. Salman Khan follows Bachchan to embrace TV

» OTT era begins as Netflix and Amazon Prime launch in India. Viewing habits change as audiences 'binge' series



COLOUR DAWN The earlier avatar of the colour TV set

to the goody-goody aims of public broadcasting, the story of Basesar Ram & Family offered unending immersion, unlike with a film. Viewers were hooked. Advertisers lined up—Maggi 2-Minute Noodles debuted on its aisles. Soap-operatic intoxication continued with newer potions. From 2.1 million TV sets with an estimated 15 million viewership in 1982, India zoomed to over 15 million sets and a viewership of 75 million by the end of the Eighties. Now that entertainment had been domesticated, a segment of households plugged in a VCR. For a while, it looked like video might kill the film star. Cinema has never ceased fighting that competition. The boundaries were fraught, but also porous. To spruce up its programming slate, DD reached out to filmmakers. Many obliged. Mahesh Bhatt made *Janam* for TV. Shyam Benegal did *Bharat Ek Khoj*. And the biggest blockbusters came from crossover folks: Ramesh Sippy's *Buniyaad* (1986), Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayan* (1987), B.R. Chopra's *Mahabharat* (1989).

The wheel spun in wider and wider circles thereafter: DD's long monopoly being broken by liberalisation and satellite television, the rise to stardom of the remote button as channels proliferated, local as well as global, and then what you might call the next set of migrants from the world of cinema. Shobha and Ekta Kapoor, wife and daughter of Jeetendra, a prototypical film actor from another era, changed the dynamics of television programming with their 'K' dramas. And by the time Amitabh Bachchan debuted on TV with *Kaun Banega Crorepati* in 2000, no one was in any doubt that small was phenomenally big. ■